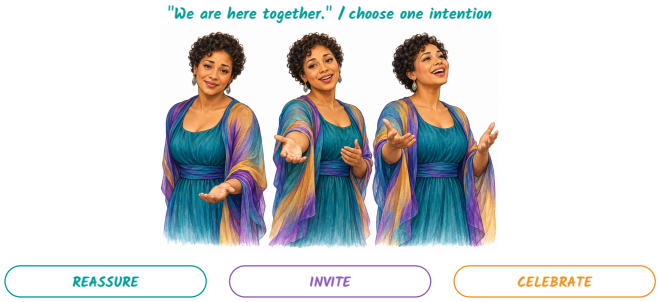
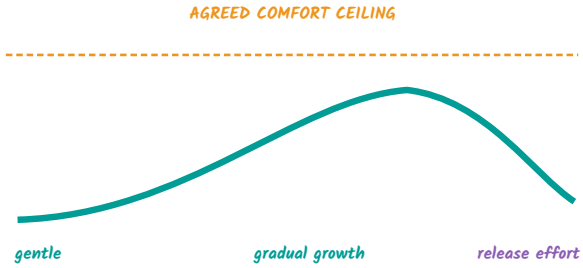
MODULE 09

Expression & Interpretation

Let musical choices communicate the text.



One Phrase, One Intention



Crescendo With a Ceiling

TEN ACTIVITIES IN THIS MODULE

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90 Listener's Story Test

Choose one goal. Try one illustrated task. Carry what works into your music.

ACTIVITY 081

One Phrase, One Intention

Expression & Interpretation

6 minutes / One short lyric line.

Give a lyric a specific communicative purpose.

"We are here together." / choose one intention



REASSURE | INVITE | CELEBRATE

Try one original line with a chosen intention, using musical choices beyond volume.

1. *Read the line and choose one intention, such as reassuring, inviting, or celebrating.*
2. *Speak it to an imaginary listener without changing the words.*
3. *Sing it and let listeners describe which musical choices communicated the intention.*

DIRECTOR'S CUE

The intention is heard through phrasing, not just a louder voice.

COMMON TRAP

Using louder singing as the only expression tool.

MAKE IT WORK

Offer two intentions to choose from and permit a group response.

ACTIVITY 082

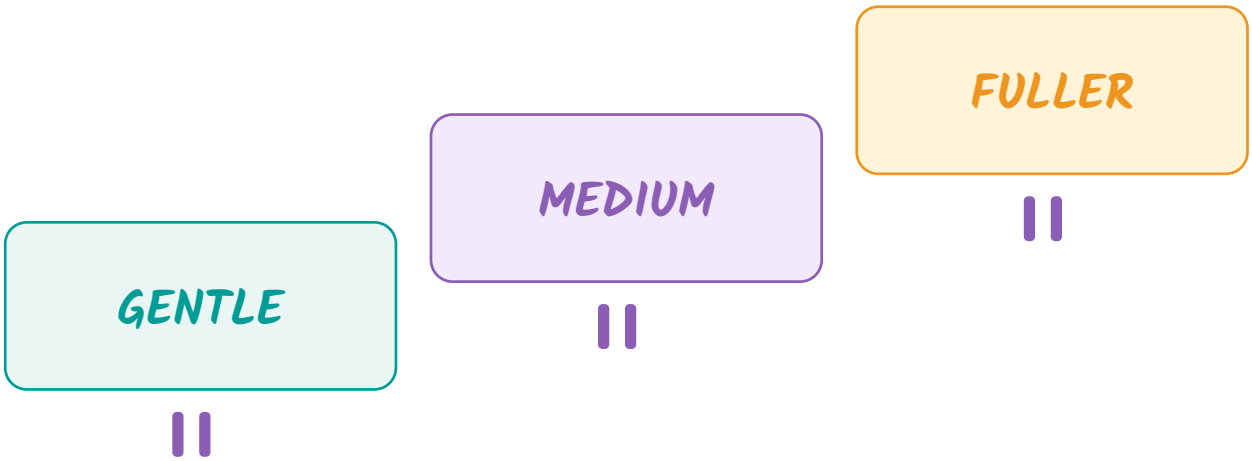
Dynamic Staircase

Expression & Interpretation

5 minutes / Three cards: gentle, medium, fuller.

Make three distinct volume levels without vocal forcing.

Rest between levels; keep the voice comfortable



Three clear levels, with rests. Stop before any singer needs to push.

1. *Sing one comfortable note briefly at a gentle but clear level.*
2. *Repeat at medium and then fuller volume, stopping before any singer needs to push.*
3. *Reverse the order and transfer the three levels to short phrases, keeping a rest between them.*

DIRECTOR'S CUE

The levels differ clearly while the tone remains comfortable.

COMMON TRAP

Forcing the fullest level to make the steps obvious.

MAKE IT WORK

Use only gentle and medium levels if those cover today's needs.

ACTIVITY 083

Phrase Destination

Expression & Interpretation

6 minutes / A lyric with a clear central word.

Shape a line toward one meaningful word.

Lead toward the meaning



We sing **together** today

Keep the words around it clear

Shape the phrase toward its main word, then let the remaining text release naturally.

1. Read the line and agree which word carries its main message.
2. Sing toward that word with a small sense of direction, then release the remaining text naturally.
3. Compare with a flat version and choose the amount of shaping that fits the style.

DIRECTOR'S CUE

The destination is audible without losing the words around it.

COMMON TRAP

Turning the destination word into a hard accent.

MAKE IT WORK

Draw one arrow above the text; avoid treating the target as a shouted accent.

ACTIVITY 084

Question and Answer

Expression & Interpretation

6 minutes / Two adjacent phrases or two original lines.

Give two musical phrases contrasting functions.

"Are you ready?"

"We are ready."



INVITES A RESPONSE



COMPLETES THE IDEA

Question and answer can have contrasting functions without becoming louder.

1

Speak the first line as a question and the second as an answer.

2

Sing both on a comfortable shared note, noticing direction and punctuation.

3

Return to their melody and preserve the conversational relationship between the phrases.

DIRECTOR'S CUE

Listeners can tell which phrase invites a response and which completes it.

COMMON TRAP

Changing the words instead of their function.

MAKE IT WORK

Use 'Are you ready?' and 'We are ready' before repertoire.

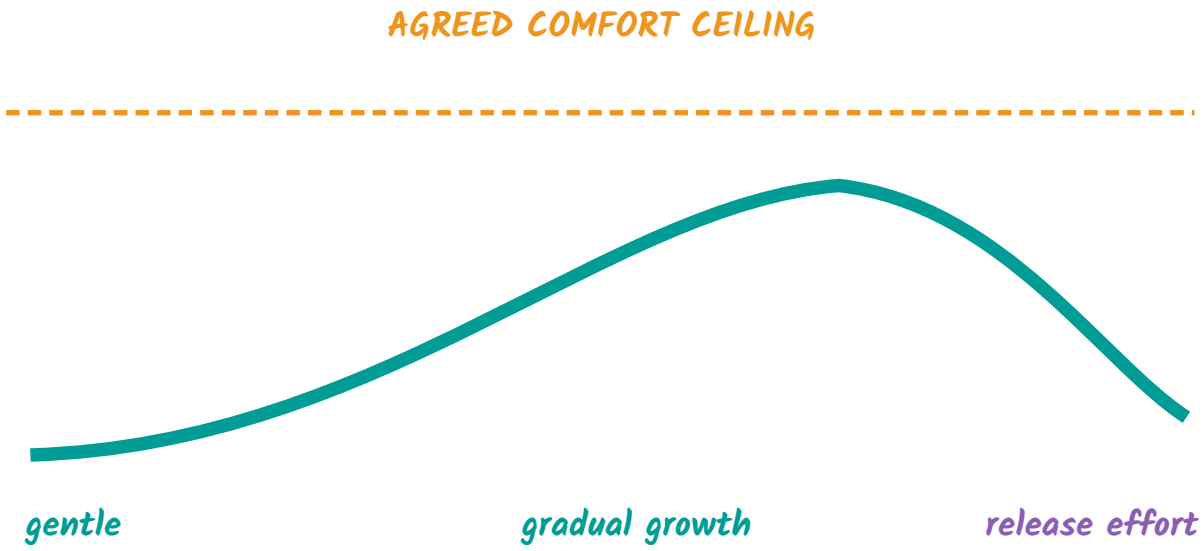
ACTIVITY 085

Crescendo With a Ceiling

Expression & Interpretation

6 minutes / Four-beat sustained note or short phrase.

Increase intensity gradually within a comfortable volume range.



Agree the comfortable ceiling first. Grow gradually and remain below it.

1. Agree a comfortable upper volume before starting; this is the ceiling, not a challenge.
2. Begin gently and increase a little over four beats without exceeding that level.
3. Repeat with a four-beat decrease, then use the shape in repertoire.

DIRECTOR'S CUE

The change is gradual and stops before the tone becomes forced.

COMMON TRAP

Letting a crescendo become a loudness challenge.

MAKE IT WORK

Use a two-level change or let singers stay at medium while listening.

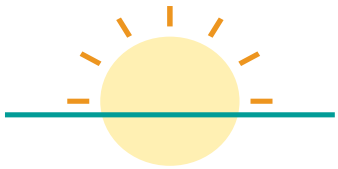
ACTIVITY 086

Text Image Gallery

Expression & Interpretation

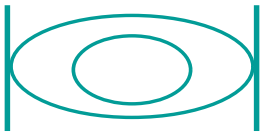
7 minutes / Three simple images or written scene descriptions.

Use a concrete image to clarify a lyric's meaning.



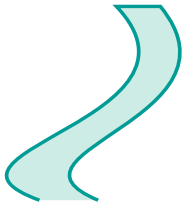
SUNRISE

beginning



SHARED MEAL

sharing



QUIET PATH

calm

An image must serve the actual lyric

Choose an image that clarifies the actual lyric: sunrise, shared meal, or quiet path.

1. *Offer a sunrise, a shared meal, and a quiet path as possible images for a selected line.*
2. *Small groups choose one and explain how it relates to the actual words.*
3. *Sing the line using that image, then name a specific phrasing choice it encouraged.*

DIRECTOR'S CUE

The image supports the text rather than replacing its meaning.

COMMON TRAP

Choosing an image that replaces the text's meaning.

MAKE IT WORK

Use verbal scene descriptions rather than pictures when visuals are inaccessible.

ACTIVITY 087

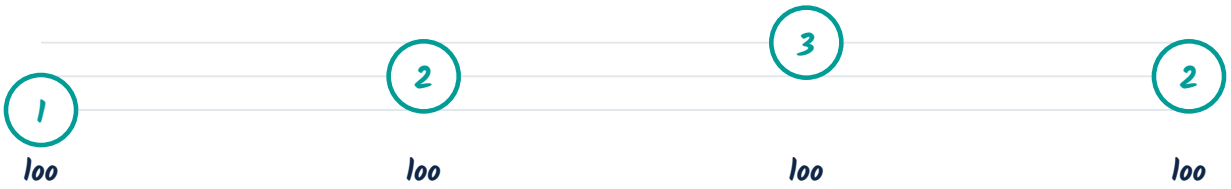
Articulation Contrast

Expression & Interpretation

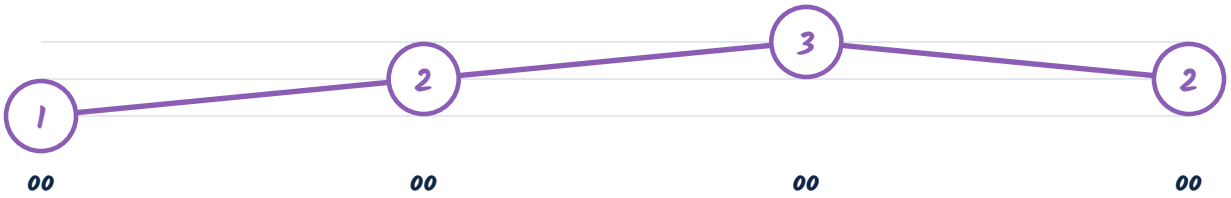
5 minutes / A four-note phrase.

Choose between connected and separated delivery intentionally.

SEPARATE SYLLABLES



ONE CONNECTED LINE



Same notes and pulse: choose a connected or gently separated delivery for a reason.

1

Sing the phrase smoothly on 'loo', then repeat with gently separated syllables.

2

Describe how the two versions change its character while keeping tempo and pitch the same.

3

Apply the version that suits the text and style, then explain the choice.

DIRECTOR'S CUE

The selected articulation is consistent across the ensemble.

COMMON TRAP

Changing tempo while comparing articulation.

MAKE IT WORK

Use spoken syllables if singing both versions becomes tiring.

ACTIVITY 088

Emotional Volume Myth

Expression & Interpretation

6 minutes / One expressive lyric line.

Communicate a strong feeling without assuming louder is better.

DICTION

Clear a word

TIMING

Allow a pause

PHRASE DIRECTION

Lead to a word

Three expressive tools at a moderate volume. Choose one that communicates the feeling.

1. Choose a feeling such as wonder or reassurance and speak the words in a natural voice.
2. Sing at a moderate volume, changing diction, timing, or phrase direction to communicate it.
3. Ask listeners which detail carried the feeling; compare two gentle interpretations.

DIRECTOR'S CUE

Listeners identify expressive details beyond volume.

COMMON TRAP

Assuming a strong feeling needs a loud voice.

MAKE IT WORK

Use an ensemble discussion rather than individual demonstrations.

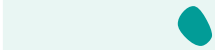
ACTIVITY 089

Endings That Mean Something

Expression & Interpretation

6 minutes / Three lines ending with different punctuation.

Match the end of a phrase to its punctuation and message.



statement



question



exclamation

Plan the ending to fit the sentence

Plan the vowel, final consonant and release so the ending supports the sentence.

1. Speak one statement, one question, and one exclamation without changing their printed words.
2. Sing each on a short pattern and plan its final vowel, consonant, and release.
3. Transfer the appropriate ending to repertoire and compare the effect on the whole line.

DIRECTOR'S CUE

The ending supports the sentence rather than simply becoming quieter by habit.

COMMON TRAP

Making every ending fade by habit.

MAKE IT WORK

Work with one type of ending per rehearsal.

ACTIVITY 090

Listener's Story Test

Expression & Interpretation

7 minutes / A short passage and two listener volunteers.

Check whether an interpretation communicates a clear narrative.

INTENDED MESSAGE

Write one message

LISTENER HEARS

Listen without clues

ONE ADJUSTMENT

Change one musical detail

Keep the intended message from the listeners until after the first performance.

1. *Agree the intended message before the choir sings, but do not tell the listeners yet.*
2. *Sing once and ask listeners to describe what they understood from the text and musical delivery.*
3. *Compare responses with the intended message and adjust one feature before repeating.*

DIRECTOR'S CUE

The second performance communicates the agreed message more clearly.

COMMON TRAP

Telling the listeners the answer before they listen.

MAKE IT WORK

Use two sections of the choir as listeners and performers.